

THE FOUR OLDS

substance draft for checkpoint 3

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INT. CABLE NEWS STUDIO - NIGHT

Election night. A wall-sized map, most of it undecided gray. Confetti

cannons stand by, unfired.

The board flips a state blue. Then another. A production assistant

claps twice, alone, then stops.

ANCHOR

At eleven-oh-four eastern, we can now project — Zoran Marwani, the junior senator from New York, the first DSA-affiliated nominee ever to carry a major party — has been elected President of the United States.

The studio erupts. Balloons fall on the news desk. Someone has printed

HISTORY IS HEALING on a bedsheet in the crowd outside the window.

The COMMENTATOR, silver-haired, removes his glasses. His eyes are wet

on camera.

COMMENTATOR

Forty-one years I've covered this building. Perhaps tonight — perhaps tonight begins the reconciliation with a world the last administration spent years insulting.

The chyron below him rolls: MARKETS "CAUTIOUS." ALLIES "JUBILANT."

EXT. NATIONAL MALL - DAY

Two months later. Inauguration crowd to the horizon. On the jumbotron,

PRESIDENT MARWANI, 41, hand off the Bible, already at the podium. Flags

on the stage: the fifty stars, and beside it, same height, the UN blue.

MARWANI

(on the jumbotron)

I do not stand here to celebrate a victory. I stand here to begin a repair. On behalf of the United States — to every nation we have wronged — we are sorry.

The crowd roars. The roar rolls down the Mall in a wave.

MARWANI

(on the jumbotron)

This is not retreat. This is not surrender. This is repair.

Under the podium feed, the chyron: NOBEL COMMITTEE AWARDS
PEACE PRIZE,

CITING "THE ANNOUNCED AGENDA."

INT. C-17 CARGO BAY - DAY

Cold metal light. Pallets nose to tail, shrink-wrapped.
Under the

plastic: banded bricks of hundred-dollar bills.

A LOADMASTER walks the line with a clipboard manifest.
Stamped across

the top page: IRAN COMPENSATION FRAMEWORK — DISBURSEMENT 1
OF 12.

At the ramp, a young STATE DEPARTMENT AIDE in a
windbreaker turns his

back to the pallets, raises his phone, and takes a selfie.
He checks

it. Takes a better one.

INT. GRAND HALL, BRUSSELS - DAY

Chandeliers. A long table of ministers. The U.S. TREASURY
SECRETARY

signs a document the size of a phone book; a European minister pats

his shoulder twice.

Champagne comes out on trays. The chyron on the broadcast feed:

U.S. COMMITS \$200 BILLION TO EUROPEAN DEFENSE RENEWAL.
Below it, a

stock ticker, all red.

ON A PHONE SCREEN

A push alert stacks over a family photo: WHITE HOUSE
UNVEILS

"STEWARDSHIP ACT" - PRIVATE ASSETS ABOVE \$1B TO BE
ADMINISTERED IN

THE PUBLIC INTEREST.

A thumb swipes it away. Another alert lands on top of it.

INT. SENATE HEARING ROOM - DAY

Packed gallery. MAGNUS HALE alone at the witness table,
reading from

a single prepared page. His voice is level and dead.

HALE

Frontier is proud to serve the
goals of this administration, at
home
and beyond it.

SENATOR

"Proud." That's good. Because some
of my colleagues feel a capability
this essential shouldn't rest in
private hands at all. There's a
word
for the remedy. I want you to hear
me say it slowly. Nationalization.

The Senator leans back. Cameras click.

Hale folds his page in half, and in half again, and says
nothing.

INT. ROY'S DINER - MORNING

A counter town diner. Six regulars, coffee, forks down.
Nobody talks.

On the wall TV, muted: the Brussels champagne, the falling
balloons,

the jumbotron apology, cycling.

EARLENE, 60s, refills BUCK's cup. Buck, 70s, feed cap,
doesn't look up

from the counter. The COOK stands in the pass-through
window, towel

over his shoulder, watching the muted TV. He doesn't move.

Under everything, a radio on the back shelf, volume near
zero:

RADIO (V.O.)

...effective January first, the
private sale and discharge of
consumer
fireworks is prohibited
nationwide, under the
administration's binding
carbon framework. Municipal
displays may apply for cultural
exemption
through the...

Nobody moves to turn it up. The percolator finishes. Buck
turns his

cup a quarter turn on the saucer.

BUCK

Huh.

He drinks.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE FOUR OLDS

INT. FIRST PLAINS BANK, BROKEN BOW, NEBRASKA - DAY

Fluorescent light, carpet tiles, one teller window open. A
cardboard

sign on an easel by the door: THE STEWARDSHIP ACT —
WORKING FOR

COMMUNITIES LIKE YOURS. Nobody is looking at it.

CRICKET DAWES, 79, sits in the waiting area. Pressed white
shirt,

buttoned to the collar. A manila folder square on his
knees, both

hands on it.

A LOAN OFFICER, 30s, tie too new, opens his office door.

OFFICER

Mr. Dawes? Sorry about the wait.

INT. LOAN OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Cricket sits. Sets the folder on the desk, turned so it
faces the

officer. The officer wakes his monitor.

OFFICER

How's the morning treating you?

CRICKET

Fine.

OFFICER

Good. That's — good.

He opens the folder. County letterhead on top. He reads it
and his

mouth goes flat.

CRICKET

County reassessed in March. Four
thousand two hundred six dollars,
due the fifteenth. I have two
thousand one hundred.

OFFICER

Okay.

CRICKET

I'm asking for six months.

The officer types. Reads his screen. Types again.

OFFICER

So — the hardship extension
program. That's the one that would
fit
you. It's showing "suspended
pending federal review." That came
down
in January with the new remittance
rules. It's not us, it's the—

He stops himself. Turns the monitor a few inches toward
Cricket.

CRICKET

The screen says no.

OFFICER

The screen says no.

He scrolls. Stops. Squints at something.

OFFICER

Mr. Dawes, this deposit line — you
receive a quarterly direct deposit
from NASA. Of zero dollars and
zero cents.

CRICKET

Clerical thing. Fifty years now.

OFFICER

Every quarter? They send you
nothing? On purpose?

CRICKET

Regular as the light bill.

The officer looks at the entry a moment longer. The
account

description field reads: DAWES, E. — ASTRONAUT (ACTIVE).

OFFICER

It has your occupation as—

CRICKET

It's old.

The officer looks at Cricket. Cricket looks back, level.
It is not

his business, and the officer decides so.

OFFICER

Right.

He pulls a form from the drawer. Fills a line. Stamps it, then

re-inks the stamp and stamps a date box twice, hard.

OFFICER

I can log your paperwork as received next cycle. That gives you sixty days before it's delinquent. It's not six months. It's what I've got.

CRICKET

Sixty days.

OFFICER

I'm sorry it's not more.

Cricket stands. Squares the folder under his arm. Puts out his hand.

The officer shakes it.

CRICKET

You did what the screen let you.

Cricket goes. The officer sits back down, pulls the monitor back to

face him, and looks at the zero-dollar deposit line for a moment.

Then he closes the file.

EXT. FIRST PLAINS BANK, PARKING LOT - DAY

Cricket sits in his pickup, folder on the bench seat, keys in his

hand. Through the windshield: the courthouse across the square, and

above it, the flag, moving.

He watches it one moment. He starts the truck.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

A work light on a beam. Filling half the barn: a homebuilt simulator —

plywood, angle iron, salvaged instrument panels, a real crew couch

bolted to a welded frame. Every switch is real. Every label is

hand-lettered.

Along the back wall, shelving floor to roof: spiral notebooks, hundreds

of them, spines out, each spine dated in the same hand. The first

shelf starts at 1972.

CRICKET, headset on, drops into the couch and brings the panel up.

Breakers click in a practiced order. An amber bus light steadies.

At his elbow, a ham radio rig glows. He keys it.

CRICKET

Net's open. Tuesday, nineteen-oh-two local.

STITCH (FILTERED)

There he is.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Before anything else — Bus B. It sagged on us last week. What's it read.

CRICKET

Twenty-eight point one.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Then the relay held. That's the '84 relay. Nothing wrong with '84.

GUNNY (FILTERED)

Gentlemen, it is nineteen-oh-two and we are burning dark. Commander, run your card.

CRICKET

Guidance internal. Tanks at sixty-two percent, simulated. Descent program loaded.

The barn door rolls open a foot. PEG, 77, in a house coat, sets a

thermos on the workbench.

PEG

Tell Elmore his wife says quit at ten. She's got a phone bill says he won't.

Cricket lifts two fingers off the throttle without looking back. Peg

pulls the door to behind her.

STITCH (FILTERED)

Was that Peg?

CRICKET

Coffee's here, if you can smell it from Lufkin.

STITCH (FILTERED)

I about can. All right, put her down. Descent rate, call it three feet a second.

CRICKET

Two point eight.

STITCH (FILTERED)

That's what I said.

Cricket flies. Hands easy on the controls. The panel needles track.

Then an ammeter needle drops and wanders. A low buzz under the hum.

CRICKET

Bus B again. Needle's walking.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

That buzz — is it steady or does it stutter?

CRICKET

Stutters.

DUTCH (FILTERED)

Inverter case. Kick it, low left corner. With respect.

Cricket kicks the case, low left corner. The needle climbs home. The

buzz quits.

STITCH (FILTERED)
Fifty years of aerospace engineering.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
You want to keep your boot behind the line next time, Commander. That machine has seniority on every man on this net.

CRICKET
Three hundred feet. Drifting left. Correcting.

Silence on the net. Only the hum and the switch clicks. His hands

make small moves. The rate needle eases down. Down.

A panel lamp lights: CONTACT.

CRICKET
Contact light. Engine stop.

A beat of quiet on the net.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
Smooth.

STITCH (FILTERED)
I've seen smoother.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
You have not.

CRICKET
Net closed. Same time Tuesday.

DUTCH (FILTERED)
God willing.

Cricket keys the mic twice — two clicks. Two clicks come back. Then

two more. Then two more. He powers the rig down.

He takes a fresh spiral notebook page and writes,
ballpoint, block

letters: T+2,806. BUS B CORRECTED. CONTACT 19:41. CREW
PRESENT BY

RADIO.

He shelves the notebook with the others. Runs his thumb
once down

the dated spines on his way to the light switch - 1974,
1988, 2003 -

and pulls the cord.

EXT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket rolls the door shut and snaps a padlock through
the hasp. He

tests it with one pull.

Beyond the barn, the farmhouse porch light.

He crosses to the house, thermos under his arm.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Supper cleared. Peg dries dishes at the sink. Cricket at
the kitchen

table with the county tax letter, a legal pad, and a
pencil, doing

long division he's already done twice.

The wall phone rings. Curly cord. Cricket takes it
standing.

CRICKET

Dawes.

INT. DANNY'S KITCHEN, KEARNEY - NIGHT - INTERCUT

DANNY DAWES, 50, stands in his own kitchen, TV light
moving on the

wall behind him, remote in his free hand.

DANNY

Hey, Dad. Roads are clear down here, finally. They got the sale barn running Thursdays again, so that's — Rachel says hi. Kids are good.

CRICKET

Good.

DANNY

Yeah.

A pause. Danny looks at his TV. Presses mute.

DANNY

Dad. Maybe don't watch the news tonight.

Cricket stands there a second. Peg has stopped drying.

CRICKET

Thank you for calling.

He hangs up. Crosses to the parlor TV and turns it on.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, PARLOR - CONTINUOUS

On the screen: the White House briefing room, then MARWANI at a

lectern, flanked by the UN flag and a folded blue banner on a stand.

MARWANI

(on TV)

Tonight I can announce the Lunar Heritage Neutralization Accord. Fifty-seven years ago, one nation planted its banner on ground that belongs to all mankind. Not as conquest, we were told. And yet the banner stayed. It stayed through every apology we owed and never gave.

Peg comes to the parlor doorway, dish towel over her shoulder.

MARWANI

(on TV)

Science tells us those six flags
are bleached white now — fifty
years of unfiltered sun. White
flags. Flags of surrender, if we
are
honest with ourselves. So we will
retire them with dignity. We will
return them to Earth. And we will
gift them — one to each nation
America has wronged. The first, to
the people of Iran.

The screen cuts to a graphic. On the left: the archive
photo,

Aldrin's salute, the flag hard-colored against black. On
the right:

a computer rendering of the same flag, boiled white,
captioned

ARTIST'S RENDERING — CURRENT CONDITION.

MARWANI

(on TV)

In their place will fly the
Harmony Banner — designed by a
committee
of forty-four nations. Not one
nation's pride. Not one nation's
claim. One planet's promise. The
retrieval will be broadcast live,
this coming July fourth. Not
Independence Day. This year, the
first
Unity Day.

Applause from the briefing room press corps. Marwani does
not smile.

He nods, slowly, eyes down.

Peg picks a dish back up and dries it. Dries it harder.
Sets it down

in the rack with a crack of china on china that makes no
one flinch

because no one else is there.

Cricket watches to the end of the segment. An ANCHOR comes
back on.

ANCHOR

(on TV)
— being called the most generous
act in the history of spaceflight.

Cricket turns the set off. Sets the remote down square on
the arm

cover. Stands a moment in the dark parlor.

Then he goes back to the kitchen, takes the wall phone off
the hook,

and dials from memory — seven digits, then four more.

CRICKET
(into phone)
You watching this?

DUTCH (V.O.)
(through the phone)
I'm watching it.

Neither man says anything. On the muted parlor TV behind
Cricket,

visible through the doorway: the white rendering again,
full screen.

CRICKET
(into phone)
Tuesday. Early.

He hangs the phone on its cradle, gently.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM - DAY

Two black SUVs come up the drive doing about half the
speed of the

county flatbed truck behind them. They park in a row,
doors open

together.

Cricket steps off the porch and stands waiting, shoulders
back.

ADMINISTRATOR PELL, 50s, lanyard over a zip fleece, gets
out reading

a folder, and doesn't look at Cricket at all. Behind him a COUNTY

DEPUTY, 40s, and four MOVERS in matching polos.

PELL

Mr. Dawes! There he is. This is a routine action, sir, nothing dramatic. The county's executing on the delinquent assessment — that's their side. I'm only here for the federal paperwork.

CRICKET

The bank logged my paperwork received next cycle. I have sixty days.

PELL

With the bank. You have sixty days with the bank. Federal interest doesn't wait on county calendars, and county enforcement doesn't wait on banks. Three governments, Mr. Dawes. You're only current with one of them.

He hands Cricket a pink sheet without stopping his walk to the barn.

INT. DAWES BARN - CONTINUOUS

The movers roll the door wide. Daylight falls across the simulator.

MOVER #1:

What is this thing?

Nobody answers him. Pell circles the rig, checking it against an

inventory sheet.

PELL

Item one. Homebuilt trainer, gyroscopic couch, panels — one altitude indicator—

CRICKET

Attitude.

Pell looks at the sheet. Makes a small correction with his pen.

PELL

Noted.

He peels a long orange sticker off a backing sheet and lays it

across the main panel, smoothing it down with his thumb:
FEDERAL

INTEREST — SENSITIVE AEROSPACE TRAINING APPARATUS —
EXCLUDED FROM

PUBLIC AUCTION.

CRICKET

Excluded from auction. So the
county can't even sell it to cover
the taxes. Then this isn't about
the taxes.

PELL

It's about compliance, Mr. Dawes.
Everything is about compliance
now. That's what makes it fair.

The movers unbolt the crew couch. A ratchet slips; a mover
barks a

knuckle and swears; Cricket hands him the correct socket
off the

pegboard. The mover takes it and can't look at him.

The Deputy stands near the door with his thumbs in his
belt,

studying the dirt floor.

Pell reaches the logbook wall. Hundreds of dated spines.
He runs his

pen light along a shelf, pulls one notebook, flips three
pages of

grid-ruled block printing.

PELL

Personal papers.

He drops it back in its slot, crooked.

PELL
No salvage value. Leave them.

EXT. DAWES FARM - LATER

The simulator rides the flatbed in pieces, chained at four corners.

The movers file past the porch. Peg holds the screen door open for

them and nods each one through.

PEG
Watch the doorframe, boys. You'll
be bringing it back through it.

The Deputy is last. He hands Cricket the county copy, folded small.

DEPUTY
There's an appeal window at the
courthouse. It's open till four.

CRICKET
Thank you, Wade.

The Deputy gets in his cruiser. Pell pauses at his SUV door and

takes in the farm, the barn, the sky. He nods at each.

PELL
Folks, I know change feels sudden.
But as the Accord reminds us —
harmony is a verb.

He gets in. The convoy pulls out, flatbed last. Dust hangs over the

drive and settles.

INT. DAWES BARN - DUSK

The barn, half empty. Where the simulator stood: a clean rectangle

of dust, bolt holes at the corners.

Cricket stands at its edge. Peg comes in and stands next to him.

Neither says anything for a while. Straight backs, both of them.

PEG
Supper's on in twenty.

She goes. Cricket looks at the rectangle one more moment.

Then he crosses to the workbench — they left the radio — pulls the

stool in, and keys the mic.

CRICKET
(into mic)
Net's open. Wednesday.

Static. Then, fast:

DUTCH (FILTERED)
Copy Wednesday.

STITCH (FILTERED)
Copy.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
About time.

Cricket sets the mic down and reaches up and pulls the work light on.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

Lunch rush. Nine customers. The TV is up loud now.

ON THE TV: a Unity Day promo. A loft apartment somewhere with exposed

brick and forty people in matching UNITY DAY shirts, cheering a

countdown clock. Below them the crawl: 62 DAYS TO UNITY DAY — NATIONS

OF HONOR ANNOUNCED FRIDAY.

At the counter: BUCK, same stool. WADE the deputy, in uniform, eating

eggs two stools down, hat crown-up on the counter beside him.

The COOK works the flat-top. Zip-tied to the gas line at his elbow: a

gray box with a digital readout and a county seal. It ticks up as he

cooks.

COOK
(to the box)
Yeah, I see you.

The diner door bell rings. Cricket comes in, takes the end stool.

Earlene has coffee in front of him before he's square on the seat.

She doesn't write a ticket. Down the counter, nobody turns his way.

Buck slides the sugar caddy to within Cricket's reach without

looking up from the TV.

ON THE TV: the watch-party promo gives way to a panel. The white

ARTIST'S RENDERING fills the screen again.

PANELIST
(on TV)
— and honestly the flags are the last piece of it. This is a president finishing an argument America started losing in 1969—

BUCK
Fifty years we kept commies off the Moon. Turns out all they had to do was win a primary.

EARLENE
Buck.

BUCK
I said it quiet.

Wade's cup has been empty a while. Earlene stands three feet from

the pot, wiping the counter. Wade looks at the cup, then doesn't

look at it again. He slides two dollars under the saucer, takes his

hat, and goes. The bell rings behind him.

The Cook flips the TV with the remote — to the ball game, pregame,

crowd shots from a half-empty stadium.

STADIUM ANNOUNCER

(on TV)

...invite you to rise, as
tonight's ceremonies open with
"One World
Rising," performed by the Tri-
Cities Children's Harmony Choir.

A synthesizer swells on the broadcast. On screen, some of the crowd

stands. A lot of it doesn't.

The Cook turns the sound down, not off, and goes back to the

flat-top.

Buck, not looking up from his coffee, starts humming. Low, to

himself. Four notes in, it's the anthem.

The Cook's spatula picks up the time against the grill edge, small,

maybe not even on purpose. At the register, Earlene hums the next

bar while she counts a stranger's change.

Nobody stands. Nobody looks at anybody. The counter hums it to the

end of the verse and stops, and the diner goes back to forks and

plates.

Cricket finishes his coffee, reaches for his wallet.

EARLENE

It's paid.

Cricket looks down the counter. Buck watches the ball game.

CRICKET

Obliged.

He puts his cap on and goes. The bell rings. Through the window, his

pickup pulls out, and beyond it, across the square, the courthouse

flag on its pole.

The meter on the gas line ticks up. The Cook watches it a second.

COOK

(to the grill)

Hum louder, Buck.

CUT TO:

INT. AMERICAN LEGION POST 219, BACK ROOM - NIGHT

A wood stove, folding chairs, a percolator going. On the wall, unit

photos going back to Korea.

GUNNY TIBBS, 71, squares the folding chairs to the table, exact. DUTCH HAAS, 76, sits with a thick ring binder in

front of him, closed, both hands on it. STITCH MCGREW, 74, is tipped

back on two legs of his chair, hat over one knee.

Cricket comes in, takes off his cap.

STITCH

You're shorter than you sound on the radio.

CRICKET

You're older.

GUNNY

Gentlemen. Sit where I put you.

They sit. A beat. Four faces that have been voices for years, taking
each other in.

DUTCH

Before anyone says anything. I've been talking to a fella at Frontier. Cargo side, twenty years. He's sound. I'd sign for him.
Hear him out.

A knock — two, then two. Gunny opens the door.

MACK BOONE, 55, work jacket, comes in with a thermos under his arm

and one sheet of paper in his hand. He nods to the room, sets the

thermos down, and lays the sheet flat in the middle of the table,

squared to the edges.

Nobody touches it. Then Dutch rotates it with two fingers, reads two

lines, and goes very still.

MACK

That's the manifest requirement for the flag retrieval. Six museum-grade containment units. Class-A archival spec. Climate control, nitrogen purge, independent power, seventy-two-hour autonomy. It's a life-support system with a museum sticker on it.

Beat.

MACK

Spec was written by a man in this room.

Stitch's chair comes down on four legs.

STITCH

Hold on. Why are you bringing this to a VFW fish-fry crowd?

Frontier's
got ten thousand people with
badges.

MACK

Badges is the problem. We're under
a Federal Compliance Monitorship.
Every badge logged, every hour
tagged, a minder in every meeting.
One employee fingerprint on
anything and it's nationalization
by
Friday and kids with mortgages
doing federal time. Zero employees
can touch this. It has to be men
who don't exist on a payroll.

DUTCH

The fleet's fly-by-cloud. Every
system phones home to the mission
net. You can't fly a man dark on
that ship.

MACK

The ship, no. The cargo, yes. The
mission rides your spec, Dutch —
the '98 spec, word for word,
because nobody's improved it
since.
Pre-network. Analog. Self-
contained. The only thing on that
manifest
the cloud can't see inside.

Dutch opens his binder. Finds a tab. Looks a long moment
at his own

handwriting from thirty years ago.

DUTCH

Seventy-two hours autonomy. Sized
generous. I sized it.

GUNNY

And when it goes wrong, son? When
somebody counts crates?

MACK

Then I lose track of scrap.
County'll tell you — it's a
documented
deficiency. I've been written up
twice.

GUNNY

And the four men in the crates?
What's their leverage on us -
what,
they gonna cancel my Medicare on
the Moon?

Quiet. The stove ticks. Mack looks around the table, one
face at a

time, and says it plain.

MACK

So. You gentlemen want to go to
the Moon?

Nobody speaks. The percolator finishes and clicks off.
Stitch looks

at Dutch. Dutch looks at Cricket.

Cricket puts his cap on, pushes his chair back, and walks
out. The

door bangs. Through the window, his pickup's dome light
comes on.

The room holds. Gunny looks at Mack. Mack doesn't move.

The door bangs again and Cricket comes back in carrying
logbooks -

a two-arm load of spiral notebooks, dust still on the
covers. He

drops them on the table, on top of the spec sheet, hard
enough to

jump the coffee cups.

Fifty years of Tuesdays, dated spine after dated spine.

CRICKET

I'm current.

Nobody laughs.

STITCH

Well.

Stitch reaches over and takes the top logbook and starts
reading.

Dutch pulls the whole stack toward the binder. Gunny
stands, pours

five cups, and sets them down one at a time — the last one
in front

of Mack.

Mack slides the spec sheet out from under the logbooks,
crosses to

the stove, opens the door, and feeds the page in. It
catches at the

corner and goes.

MACK

Then this meeting never happened.

INT. DAWES BARN - THAT NIGHT

The work light. Cricket at the ham rig, an open Reader's
Digest

propped against the coffee can. He reads letter groups off
the page

under a thumbnail and keys them out in morse — short,
patient

strings.

Somewhere out in the dark, twice, an acknowledgment: two
clicks.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, FABRICATION BAY 2 - DAY

A cathedral of a shop floor. Gantry cranes, weld curtains,
a bell

nozzle the size of a grain silo up on stands. Two hundred
workers in

company blues stand in loose ranks, hoods up, gloves off.

Among them: TITO ALVAREZ, 24, welding hood pushed back, a
smear of

soot to the jaw.

At a portable lectern: MIRA VESS, 40s, charcoal suit, no notes.

Off her shoulder, ADMINISTRATOR PELL with a tablet, recording. At

the back of the ranks, MACK BOONE stands with his arms folded.

VESS

I will not waste your morning.
Under the Compliance Monitorship,
Frontier's fabrication footprint
exceeds the mission profile the
government has assigned us.
Effective today, Bay Two is
closed.
Two hundred positions are
eliminated.

Silence. Then a stir through the ranks, voices low and getting less

low.

WORKER

My father cut the first nozzle
ring in this bay!

VESS

I know he did. His name is on the
wall of the visitor center, where
tourists photograph it. This
decision is mine. Not Magnus
Hale's.
Mine. If you need somewhere to put
that, put it on me.

She lets that sit. Nobody thanks her for it.

VESS

Terms. Severance is twelve months
at full rate. Health coverage
carries the same twelve. The
tooling and heavy equipment will
be
declared surplus and sold for
scrap at public auction. Shop
inventory will be palletized and
disposed by an outside
logistics contractor.

Mack, at the back, unfolds his arms.

VESS

Last. Each of you carries a
priority-rehire designation,
should
operations resume. I do not expect
you to believe that means
anything. Keep the card anyway.

She steps off the lectern. No questions invited, none
asked. Pell

taps his tablet and leans toward her.

PELL

For the record, the Monitorship
views this as a — a meaningful
posture of alignment. I'll be
noting the, ah, expedited timeline
favorably.

VESS

Note whatever you like.

She walks the length of the bay to the doors, heels on
concrete the

only sound, two hundred men watching her go.

LATER

The ranks have broken up. Men pack toolboxes. A news crew
shoots

through the fence gate: workers filing out with toolboxes
and milk

crates.

Tito stands at his station a last moment. On the bench: a
practice

weld, two plates joined by a bead like a row of dimes. He
raps it

twice with one knuckle, picks up his hood, and walks out
past Mack.

MACK

Alvarez.

TITO

Mr. Boone.

MACK

You paid up at the union hall?

TITO
Through March.

MACK
Keep it that way.

Tito looks at him. Mack is already looking at his clipboard. Tito

carries his toolbox out into the daylight.

Mack takes a small pocket notebook from his jacket, writes one line,

and puts it away.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

A steel warehouse the size of a football field, dark, weeds in the

gravel apron. A sign on the gate: CLOSED BY ORDER - COUNTY REVENUE

RECOVERY. Under it, smaller: NO SALVAGE VALUE.

Mack's truck, then Cricket's, then two more, lights off, roll around

to the loading side.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

Flashlights. Mack finds the panel and throws breakers one at a time.

Sodium lamps bang on, row by row, until the whole dead acreage of

the place stands lit: empty auction floor, intact gantry crane,

scale pit, loading docks.

The four olds stand in the middle of it, turning slowly.

DUTCH

Three-phase power. Sixty-foot
clear span. A certified scale.

MACK

County shut it down for back taxes
and forgot it exists. I rent it
through a feed cooperative that
doesn't exist either.

A knock at the man-door — two, then two. Mack opens it.

JOSS REED, 26, hoodie, work boots, a duffel. Behind him,
TITO,

toolbox in hand, hood under his arm.

JOSS

Okay so Mack says be here at ten
and bring nothing with a battery,
which is like — literally
everything is a battery — so I
brought
Tito.

GUNNY

Son. Phones.

Gunny holds out a coffee can. Joss looks at it. Looks at
the four

old men looking at him. Drops his phone in. Tito's
follows.

MACK

(to the room)

Joss runs the dock crew days.
Fastest hands at Frontier and no
badge access to anything that
matters, which makes him
invisible.
Tito you know by his work.

Mack nods to Dutch. Dutch opens the binder on a plywood
table and

unrolls a pencil drawing over it: a crate, in section.
Dimensions,

purge lines, a battery bus. And inside the crate outline,
drawn

faint but unmistakable: the profile of a reclined man.

The kids look at it a long moment. Joss's grin goes away.

JOSS

That's a person. This is a bit,
right? Tell me the — this is not a
bit. Okay. Wow. Whose felony is
this exactly?

MACK

Nobody's, if it's done right.
Yours to walk away from, right
now,
no hard feelings and no second
chance.

Tito hasn't looked up from the drawing. He rotates it with
one

finger, frowning.

TITO

This corner joint. You spec'd a
fillet here?

DUTCH

Full-penetration bevel. Page two.

TITO

(turning the page)

Okay. Okay, yeah. But your purge
line comes through two inches from
the weld. Heat's going to cook
your fitting. Move it here, come
in
under the frame rail, nobody ever
sees it.

Dutch looks at the drawing. Looks at Tito. Takes out a
pencil and

hands it to him.

Tito takes it, bends over the sheet, and starts drawing
the new

line.

JOSS

(to Mack)

And me? I load boxes.

CRICKET

You grew up on CB. Mack says your
daddy ran freight and kept a rig
in the truck.

JOSS

Yeah. So?

CRICKET

So you're mission control.

Joss looks at Cricket a second, then at his own duffel, then back up.

JOSS

I'll need a better antenna than what I got. And you're going to want a schedule — a real one, like a net schedule — okay, yeah, I'm in, obviously I'm in.

MACK

Comms discipline. That's the whole game, so hear it once. Nothing electronic. No phones, no email, no cloud, nothing with a battery you didn't build yourself.

JOSS

Then how do two hundred guys coordinate a—

DUTCH

Handwritten letters. Ham net on schedule. A book cipher out of the Reader's Digest — Cricket has the year and the month.

JOSS

That's insane. That's like — that's Revolutionary War stuff.

GUNNY

They've got every algorithm ever written. We've got Valley Forge.

Joss opens his mouth. Closes it.

LATER

Tito, on his knees on the concrete, chalks a full-size crate

outline on the floor off Dutch's dimensions — a long rectangle,

corners squared off a framing square.

The men stand around it, looking down.

Stitch steps over the chalk line, lies down inside it, and sets his

hat on his chest.

STITCH

Snug.

CUT TO:

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAY

The auction floor is a training floor now. A taped lane down the

concrete. A wooden step box. Four army cots. An eye chart hung on

the far wall, a long way off.

Dutch sits at a child's school desk, the binder open beside a stack

of carbon-copy forms. The top form, fresh-printed to match a

fifty-eight-year-old original: FLIGHT CREW MEDICAL EXAMINATION -

STANDARDS OF 1968.

DUTCH

Gentlemen. NASA wrote a physical in 1968. It is the last standard that ever mattered, and it is the one in this binder. We do all of it or none of it.

JOSS

(raising a hand)

Question. Is there a version of this where we just - there's literally an app that does a full-

GUNNY

Son.

Gunny points at Joss's wrist. The smartwatch. Then at the coffee can

on the plywood table.

JOSS

It's a WATCH.

GUNNY

It's a battery you didn't build.

JOSS

Okay, okay — last thing it does,
then. Science. For science.

THE STEP TEST

Cricket, sleeves rolled, steps up and down on the box to
Gunny's

count. Steady the whole count. Joss holds his watch near
Cricket's

wrist, eyes on the little screen.

Cricket steps down. Stands easy. Breathes through his
nose.

JOSS

Two minutes post-exercise...
fifty-four. Resting fifty-one. Old
dude's resting heart rate
embarrassed my watch. My watch
cost four
hundred dollars.

CRICKET

Farm rate. Ask the bank, they've
seen the light bill.

Joss looks at the watch, then walks it to the coffee can
and drops

it in.

THE EYE CHART

Stitch, hand over one eye, all the way across the
warehouse from

the chart.

STITCH

Bottom's got a print date and a
union bug. You want those too?

DUTCH

(writing)

Line eleven. Nobody reads line
eleven.

THE STEP TEST, AGAIN

Stitch's turn on the box. On the fourth step his knee cracks loud

enough to carry across the floor. His cadence doesn't change. He

finishes the count and steps down.

Nobody says anything about it. Dutch writes without looking up.

DUTCH

Waiver, page nine. There were
waivers in '68 too. Compensating
technique documented.

STITCH

Anyway.

THE CRATE

The plywood mockup crate sits in the middle of the floor, lid on.

Inside it, unseen: Gunny. On the lid: a wind-up kitchen timer and

four twenty-dollar bills under a socket wrench.

Joss and Tito sit on the concrete nearby, backs to a post. Cricket

whittles a soft pine peg to fit a knothole.

TITO

(low, to Joss)

Bet's who asks the time first.

The timer ticks. The lid does not move.

The timer rings. Dutch lifts the lid. Gunny sits up, unhurried,

looks around at all of them, and settles on the money under the

wrench.

GUNNY

Whose twenty is on top?

JOSS

Mine.

GUNNY

It's mine now, son.

AT THE SCHOOL DESK - LATER

Dutch signs the fourth carbon form with a fountain pen.
Squares the

stack. Files all four into the binder rings and closes the
cover.

DUTCH

Four for four. Congratulations,
gentlemen. You are fit to fly -
fifty-eight years ago.

STITCH

Best year there ever was.

CUT TO:

EXT. RURAL MAILBOX, NEBRASKA - DAY

A weathered hand puts a letter in a mailbox and raises the
little

red flag. The envelope, handwritten: TRI-COUNTY FEED
COOPERATIVE,

RE: PARTS.

EXT. RURAL MAILBOX, EAST TEXAS - DAY

Another mailbox, another envelope, another red flag up. A
dog

watches from a porch.

EXT. MAILBOX ROW, SOUTH CAROLINA LOWCOUNTRY - DAY

A third. The mail carrier takes it without a glance,
tosses it in

the tray between coupon packs.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Supper cleared to one side. Peg reads from a handwritten strip of

paper, glasses down her nose.

PEG

Fourteen. Two. Nine.

Cricket thumbs a swollen 1971 Reader's Digest to page fourteen,

column two, counts nine words down, and writes one word on a pad.

PEG

Six. One. Eleven.

He flips, counts, writes. Peg looks at the pad over his shoulder.

PEG

That's a grocery list.

CRICKET

This week it is.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - NIGHT

Crate number one stands in a welding jig, half-skinned, purge lines

run neat along the frame rail where nobody will ever see them. TITO

welds, hood down, bead steady.

Around the shop, in ones and twos, MEN FROM BAY TWO work quiet

stations - machining, harness-lay, upholstery on a crash couch. A

chalkboard by the door tracks pickups in and out against feed-co-op

job tickets.

Tito lifts his hood, pulls a film camera from his toolbox, shoots

two frames of the crate, and winds the film down.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN, ROOF - NIGHT

Joss, headlamp off, feeds a wire antenna from the roof peak toward

the dead flagpole by the gate, paying it out gloved hand over hand.

Below him, Gunny holds the ladder and points, twice, at where the

tie-off goes. Joss ties it off there.

INT. STITCH'S HANGAR, EAST TEXAS - NIGHT

A crop-duster hangar. Stitch at a workbench rig, two fingers on a

morse key, sending. A fly strip turns overhead.

INT. DUTCH'S BASEMENT, WISCONSIN - NIGHT

A ham station, everything labeled, everything square. Dutch sends,

pauses, logs the exchange in pencil in a columned notebook.

EXT. GUNNY'S PORCH, SOUTH CAROLINA - NIGHT

A key wired to a TV tray. Sweet tea. Gunny sends with one finger,

slow and exact, frogs loud in the dark past the porch rail.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket copies code off the air onto the pad, letter groups filling

line after line. He keys two clicks. Somewhere, two click back.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Cricket raps the table edge with one knuckle: two, pause, two.

CRICKET

All clear.

He raps three, evenly spaced.

CRICKET

No. Stop. Trouble.

PEG

And supper?

CRICKET

There's no code for supper.

Peg raps the table twice, pause, twice — then once, hard,
on the

sugar bowl lid.

PEG

All clear, and there's pie.

Cricket looks at her a moment. Writes it on the pad.

EXT. DAWES BARN - LATER THAT NIGHT

The barn window lit. Inside, faint, morse ticking.

Peg crosses the yard in her house coat, stops at the barn
wall,

raps it twice — pause — twice. Goes back to the house.

Inside the barn, without breaking his copy rhythm, Cricket
reaches

up and flicks the work light off-on once.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, TRAINING ROOM B - DAY

Drop ceiling, stack chairs, a projector. A sign-in
clipboard chained

to the door. On the screen: CULTURAL ALIGNMENT — MODULE 7
OF 12

(MANDATORY).

Fifty workers in company blues, arms crossed. MACK in the
third

row. JOSS near the back, dock vest, sunflower seeds.

At the front, a FACILITATOR, 30s, all teeth, clicker in hand.

FACILITATOR

Okay! Module seven. Heritage. Big one. Now — history gives us frameworks for thinking about the past, and some of them are bolder than others. Slide.

The slide: a stylized portrait of MAO ZEDONG over a rising-sun

graphic, and the words: 1966 — A BOLD QUESTION: WHAT DO WE OWE THE

PAST?

FACILITATOR

In 1966, Chairman Mao's movement asked exactly that. And their answer was a framework called the Four Olds. Slide.

The slide, in clean sans-serif on harmony blue:

OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS.

FACILITATOR

Old ideas. Old culture. Old customs. Old habits. Four categories of inherited weight. And the movement asked a community to examine that weight together. Honestly? As an early framework for heritage neutralization, it was ahead of its time.

In the third row, Mack uncaps a pen and copies the slide into his

pocket notebook, word for word, block letters.

The door opens. PELL steps in, tablet against his chest, and beams

at the screen.

PELL

Don't mind me. This is the good work, folks. Centuries of ancient

Chinese wisdom in that slide.

FACILITATOR
It's from 1966—

PELL
Wonderful.

He stays, standing against the wall. The Facilitator clicks on.

FACILITATOR
Now. Nobody is saying our situation is identical. But when we watch the Accord retire tired symbols this July, we're participating in that same brave tradition of asking: does this still serve us?

JOSS
(not raising his hand)
What happened to the people who liked the old stuff?

Silence. The Facilitator's smile holds its position.

FACILITATOR
There were — implementation errors. In that era. Which is why today's frameworks center dialogue. Slide.

The slide: YOUR REFLECTION HOMEWORK — IDENTIFY ONE OLD HABIT

YOU'RE READY TO RETIRE!

FACILITATOR
Small group shares on Thursday. Sign the clipboard on your way out, it feeds your compliance score.

Chairs scrape. Fifty men file out past the clipboard, signing

without slowing down. Pell holds the door, nodding at each man like

he knows him.

IN THE CORRIDOR

Joss falls in beside Mack in the crowd.

JOSS

(low)

My grandpa's old habit was getting
shot at over Hanoi.

MACK

Write "coffee." Everybody writes
coffee.

Joss looks at him. Mack peels off toward the dock without
another

word, notebook square in his jacket pocket.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER LAUNCH COMPLEX - DAY (NEWS FOOTAGE)

Steady news-helicopter footage: the booster on its
transporter, long

as a grain elevator on its side. On its flank, fifty feet
of painted

stars and stripes.

A cherry-picker rises alongside. Two painters in white
roll primer

over the field of stars, top to bottom, one pass at a
time. The

footage does not cut away. The anchor has stopped talking.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, PRESS ROOM - DAY

Vess at a podium. Cameras. A REPORTER mid-question.

REPORTER

— but whose decision was it to
paint over the—

VESS

Mine. I ordered the repainting.
The Accord specifies neutral
mission livery. Paint is cheaper
than a receiver. That math is my
job.

REPORTER

And Mr. Hale's position on-

VESS

The board meets Thursday. Bring
it.

She steps down.

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

The repaint footage on the wall TV, the white roller
crossing the

last star.

The Cook reaches up and turns the set off. Black screen.
He goes

back to the grill. Nine customers eat in the quiet. The
carbon

meter ticks.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - DUSK

Floor-to-ceiling glass. MAGNUS HALE stands at it, hands in
his

pockets, looking down the flight line at the real thing:
the

booster, primer-white flank drying under the work lights.
A crew

tarps it for the night.

The door. Vess comes in, stops beside him at the glass.
They stand

there, not looking at each other, the white rectangle
below them.

She sets a folder on his desk on her way out. The door
closes.

Hale doesn't turn around.

CUT TO:

EXT. PIONEER FIELD, MINOR-LEAGUE BALLPARK - NIGHT

Small park, big lights, maybe nine thousand people. Kids
on the

outfield berm. The four olds and Peg sit together down the
third-base line, ball caps and popcorn.

PA ANNOUNCER (V.O.)
Ladies and gentlemen, please rise,
as tonight's ceremonies open
with "One World Rising," performed
by the Tri-Cities Children's
Harmony Choir.

The crowd gets up slow, hands in pockets. A backing track
swells

through the PA — synthesizer, chimes. The children's choir
starts,

small and dutiful, on the infield grass.

Down the first-base line, BUCK — feed cap in his fist,
flannel

tucked in for the occasion — stands looking at the flag
pole beyond

center field, the flag up there lit against the dark.

Buck opens his mouth and starts to sing. The other anthem.
The real

one. Alone, off-key, too loud, four full bars by himself
against

nine thousand people's silence and a children's choir.

Nobody joins him. Then the row behind him joins him.

Then the section. Then the far bleachers, ragged, out of
time with

each other, gaining. The backing track keeps playing
underneath,

chimes and all, buried under the voices. The children's
choir looks

at their director. The director looks at nine thousand
people, drops

her hands, and turns around to face the flag pole.

The four olds do not sing. Hats off, on their feet. Gunny stands at

attention, thumb along his trouser seam. Stitch's jaw is tight.

Dutch holds his cap over the exact center of his chest. Cricket

watches the stands — not the field, the people, row on row of them

finding the words.

Peg sings.

By the last line it is nine thousand voices and no melody to speak

of and the light towers humming over all of it.

The note dies off across the parking lots. A beat of quiet.

By the concourse rail, a COMPLIANCE KID, 20s, polo and lanyard,

stands with his tablet half-raised. He looks from the tablet to the

stands and back. He lowers the tablet and puts it away.

The crowd sits. The game just starts, like nothing happened, first

pitch a called strike.

On the scoreboard: TONIGHT'S POST-GAME LIGHT SHOW BROUGHT TO YOU BY

THE UNITY FUND. A BOY, 8, two rows down from the olds, tugs his

father's sleeve.

BOY

Is the light show the one with the booms?

FATHER

Not anymore, bud.

Cricket looks down the row. Dutch, Stitch, Gunny look back at him.

Nobody says anything. They sit, and put their caps back on, one by

one.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM - DAY

A commercial flatbed grinds up the drive - VALLEY SALVAGE &

SURPLUS painted on the door. On the bed, chained at four corners:

the simulator, in its pieces.

Every piece wears a fresh orange stencil: SCRAP - LOT 44-C.

Cricket comes off the porch. The DRIVER, 50s, coveralls, swings

down with a clipboard.

DRIVER

You Dawes?

CRICKET

I'm Dawes.

DRIVER

Sign for lot 44-C. Scrap conveyance, buyer's copy. Somebody paid the freight to here, don't ask me who, I drive.

Cricket takes the clipboard. Flips the top page. Reads.

The line items: HOMEBUILT TRAINER COMPONENTS. DISPOSITION: SOLD AS

SCRAP - NON-FUNCTIONAL. RELEASED FROM FEDERAL SURPLUS HOLDING BY

DISPOSAL CONTRACTOR.

Cricket looks at the flatbed. The panels sit intact under the

chains, gauges unbroken, his hand-lettered labels facing the sky.

CRICKET
Says non-functional.

DRIVER
It does say that.

The driver looks at the load, then at Cricket, then at his watch.

DRIVER
I got a two o'clock in Ogallala.

Cricket signs. The driver unbinds the chains.

Peg watches from the porch as the two men walk the pieces into the

barn on a hand truck, one load at a time.

PEG
Barn's where it was.

DRIVER
Yes, ma'am.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

The simulator stands whole again on its welded frame, bolted down

through the same four holes. The orange SCRAP stencil still on the

couch rail. Cricket, socket wrench in hand, looks at the stencil a

moment - and leaves it.

He drops into the couch. Breakers click in the practiced order. The

amber bus light steadies.

He pulls the headset on and keys the rig.

CRICKET
Net's open. Tuesday.

STITCH (FILTERED)
There he is.

DUTCH (FILTERED)
Bus B. What's it read.

CRICKET
Twenty-eight point four. Better
than it left.

A beat on the net.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
Run your card, Commander.

Cricket sets his hand on the throttle. Above the panel,
taped where

a mission patch would go: the pink county seizure sheet,
folded to

show the words SENSITIVE AEROSPACE TRAINING APPARATUS.

CRICKET
Guidance internal.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, CARGO INTEGRATION HALL - DAY

Clean-room bright. Six crates on cradles in a row —
museum-grade,

brushed alloy skins, purge fittings, gauges. Stenciled big
on their

flanks like stock lots:

LOT A — OLD IDEAS. LOT B — OLD CULTURE. LOT C — OLD
CUSTOMS. LOT D —

OLD HABITS. LOT E — SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT. LOT F —
SUPPLEMENTARY

CONTAINMENT.

Dock crew in bunny suits. MACK with a clipboard. JOSS on
the crane

controls. And walking the line with a tablet: PELL.

PELL
Random re-weigh. Compliance is a
rhythm, folks. Random means
random.

MACK
They weighed in at fabrication.

PELL
And now they'll weigh in at
integration.

The crane takes LOT A. Sets it on the floor scale. The
SCALE TECH,

40s, coffee thermos on the console, reads the number
against the

manifest.

SCALE TECH
Lot A. Three-eighty declared...
four-eleven-two.

Pell stops walking.

PELL
Again.

SCALE TECH
Four-eleven-two.

PELL
Weigh B.

LOT B: 413.0. LOT C: 412.6. LOT D: 409.8. Four crates, all
heavy,

thirty-some kilos each. Pell comes to the console and
reads the

display himself — manifest line, crate serial, number, in
the right

order, fast.

PELL
Thirty kilos of I-don't-know-what,
times four. My favorite kind of
number, Mr. Boone.

MACK
Could be the couch upgrade.
Archival spec revision come
through in
March—

PELL
Re-run it. Cell check first.

The hall has gone quiet enough to hear the air handlers.

The Scale Tech runs the load-cell check. Taps cell three with two

knuckles. The number stutters: 411.9... 408.2... 413.5.

He frowns at it. Looks up at the crate on the platen – at the

stencil, OLD IDEAS, at the purge gauge holding steady where a purge

gauge should hold. Looks at his own clipboard.

A long moment. Joss, up in the crane cab, sits absolutely still.

The Scale Tech writes on the log sheet, reading aloud as he writes.

SCALE TECH
Calibration drift, cell three. All
four reads invalidated.
Corrected tare applied. Within
tolerance after correction.

He initials it, tears the copy, hands it up to Pell, picks up his

thermos, and walks back to his console. He does not look at Mack on

the way.

Pell reads the sheet. Reads it again. Files it in his packet,

squared to the corner.

PELL
Hm.

He walks the row one more time and stops at LOT F.

PELL
Where's the environmental cert on
this one?

MACK
Rides with the master manifest.

PELL
The master manifest references an
attachment E-6. There is no
attachment E-6 in my packet.

Mack flips his clipboard. A beat too long.

MACK

That's a paperwork question.
Paperwork's Monday.

PELL

It's Thursday. Lot F is impounded
until I hold E-6 in my hand.
Forty-eight hours, Mr. Boone, or
it comes off the manifest and
flies nothing to nowhere.

He peels an orange IMPOUND sticker and smooths it across
Lot F's

seam with his thumb, both passes, careful.

Then, at LOT D, he stops, takes out a pen, signs the
inspection tag

himself, and slots it in the holder: INSPECTED - J. PELL.

PELL

Sleep well, gentlemen. The Accord
thanks you for your rigor.

He goes. The hall breathes. Joss climbs down from the
crane, gray

in the face. Mack watches Pell's door swing shut.

MACK

(quiet, to Joss)
Get word up the net. Gunny's gear
just went in the penalty box.

CUT TO:

INT. SENATE HEARING ROOM - DAY

The same room from the election-year grilling. The same
SENATOR,

higher on the dais now. In the witness chair: MIRA VESS,
alone, no

counsel, water glass untouched.

SENATOR

Ms. Vess. You run Frontier day to
day.

VESS

I do.

SENATOR

And Mr. Hale — the founder,
your... partner — what does he
run?

A small laugh through the gallery at the pause. Vess does
not join

it.

VESS

Magnus holds the title of founder
and chief engineer. Day-to-day
authority rests with me. It has
for six years.

SENATOR

Has Mr. Hale ever expressed
contempt for this administration's
space policy? For the Accord?

VESS

Frequently. In colorful terms. I
can provide dates.

The gallery stirs. On the press bench, pens move.

SENATOR

You'd testify your own founder is
hostile to the mission your
company is flying.

VESS

I'd testify he talks. Senator,
Magnus Hale has not directed a
covert anything in the six years I
have run his company. He is not
built for quiet. What he thinks
arrives in public, at volume,
usually by breakfast. You have his
feed. Subpoena his drafts folder
if you want the unabridged
edition.

Laughter, open now. The Senator lets it run.

SENATOR

Some of my colleagues feel that
attitude alone justifies a federal
receiver on the company through
Unity Day.

VESS

A receiver would spend six months
finding the bathrooms. Your
broadcast is in nine weeks. The
Accord flies on schedule if the
company stays in the hands that
run it. Mine.

SENATOR

And Mr. Hale?

VESS

Watch him as closely as you like.
You will find a loud man with a
clean calendar.

The Senator sits back and caps his pen.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Dark but for the wall screen: Vess in the chair, the
chyron - VESS:

FOUNDER "NOT BUILT FOR QUIET" - and a phone in Hale's
hand.

On the phone, a draft post, cursor blinking: My COO and
the mother

of my children just

His thumb hovers. Holds.

He backspaces it to nothing, sets the phone face down on
the desk,

and watches the rest in the dark.

ON THE WALL SCREEN

PANELIST (V.O.)

- because when even Mira Vess
won't defend him, what's left to
defend? The board should thank
her. Frankly the country should.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM, MAILBOX - DAY

Cricket walks the drive, takes the mail. Bills, a seed
catalog -

and one heavy envelope, government linen, eagle on the corner.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - DAY

The letter flat on the table between them. Peg reads over her

glasses.

PEG

(reading)

"...administrative review has
restored annuity status
retroactive
to separation... enclosed
disbursement reflects adjusted
back
period..."

She slides the check out of the envelope. Looks at the number. Sets

it down facing Cricket.

The check: \$184,306.00.

PEG

And the county sent one too.
Lien's released. Taxes marked
satisfied, the whole assessment.

CRICKET

Fifty years, they never paid a
nickel. Zero dollars, zero cents,
every quarter on the dot. Now,
nine weeks before their launch,
somebody in Washington finds my
file and gets generous.

Peg looks at the check. At him.

PEG

It would fix the roof. And the
truck. And the next ten years.

CRICKET

It would.

He picks up the check, evens its edges against the table,
opens the

hutch drawer, and lays it inside, flat, under the county's pink

seizure copy he never threw away.

He shuts the drawer.

CRICKET

If they're paying the roster, the
roster's real. File says
astronaut, active. I'll bill them
when I'm back.

Peg looks at him a long moment. Then she takes the empty envelope,

folds it once, and drops it in the stove kindling.

PEG

Supper's on in twenty.

CUT TO:

INT. FEDERAL FIELD OFFICE - NIGHT

Pell at his desk, late. His phone buzzes: a forwarded photo, grainy,

time-stamped 1:14 AM - box trucks backed up to the Tri-County

Auction Barn, loading doors lit.

Pell looks at it a long time. Then he prints it, pins it to a cork

board, and picks up the phone.

EXT. GUNNY'S PORCH, SOUTH CAROLINA - NIGHT

Frogs. A police scanner murmurs on the TV tray, county traffic,

numbers and street names.

Gunny sets down his sweet tea, leans to the morse key, and sends:

two clicks. A pause. Two clicks.

EXT. COUNTY ROAD, NEBRASKA - NIGHT

Hay trucks — three of them, loaded high and tarped — pull out of

the auction barn's back gate, running lights only, and spread out

onto three different section roads.

EXT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - DAWN

Four black SUVs and a box van of INSPECTORS in wind-breakers roll

up the gravel. Pell, tablet in hand, motions: roll the doors.

The doors roll.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

A carousel.

Dismantled across the whole floor — carved horses in ranks on

padded trestles, brass poles in racks, a ring of men with brushes

and gold leaf and coffee. Two hundred of them, easy. The

gantry crane holds a palomino mid-air on soft slings.

A banner across the back wall: CUSTER COUNTY FAIR
CENTENNIAL —

CAROUSEL RESTORATION PROJECT. VOLUNTEERS WELCOME.

An AM radio plays farm futures. Nobody stops working.

Pell walks in slow. An inspector behind him lifts a tarp:
horse

legs, numbered with masking tape. Another checks the scale
pit:

swept concrete, a shop-vac parked in it.

A PAINTER, 60s, gold leaf on his knuckles, looks up from a
horse's

bridle.

PAINTER

You want a brush, friend? We're
behind.

Pell doesn't answer. He walks the ranks of horses, taps
one on the

rump, reads the job board: a hauling schedule,
handwritten, pinned

next to feed-store receipts and a fair-committee
letterhead.

He checks the photo on his tablet against the loading
doors. Same

doors. He looks at the crane. At the swept pit. At two
hundred men

painting.

PELL

(reading the
banner, flat)

"Volunteers welcome."

He stands in the middle of it a moment, tablet hanging
from his

hand.

PELL

Nobody restores anything anymore.
Not for free. Not two hundred
men.

PAINTER

County pays for the gold leaf.

Pell looks at him. The Painter holds his eye, friendly,
brush

loaded and waiting.

Pell turns and walks out. The inspectors trail him. The
doors roll

shut behind them, and the barn holds still one beat –
brushes up,

nobody moving –

Then the AM radio changes to a ballgame, and the brushes
come back

down.

EXT. COUNTY ROAD - MORNING

The federal convoy heads back down the two-lane. It passes, coming

the other way, a hay truck loaded high and tarped, then a second,

then, a mile on, a third.

At the wheel of the third, cap low, arm out the window:
TITO. A

whip antenna bolted to the fender ticks in the wind.

The convoy doesn't slow. The hay rolls on.

CUT TO:

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT

Cricket packs a canvas kit bag on the workbench, item by item off a

handwritten list: logbook, slide rule, a zippo, a folded photograph

he doesn't look at.

Headlights swing across the wall. A truck door. Then DANNY in the

barn doorway, keys still in his hand.

He looks at the simulator. At the orange SCRAP stencil. At the kit

bag.

DANNY

I know what's in the barn, Dad.
I've known a year. I figured you'd
tell me when it mattered.

Cricket zips the bag halfway and stops.

DANNY

I'm not going to say any of the
things. About your age, or the
law,

or Mom. You'd just stand there and
let me finish.

CRICKET

I would.

Danny looks at the logbook shelf — the fifty years of it —
and back

at his father. Whatever he came to say next, he doesn't
say it.

DANNY

You need a driver?

CRICKET

Thursday. Four a.m. Dress like a
farmer.

DANNY

I am a farmer.

He goes. Cricket zips the bag the rest of the way.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, BEDROOM - NIGHT

The kit bag open on the bed. Peg repacks it — not
differently,

better. Rolls each item tight, wedges them square.

PEG

You'll want the—

CRICKET

It's in there.

PEG

And the spare glasses.

CRICKET

Front pocket.

She holds up two pairs of socks.

PEG

Take the good ones. Not the gray,
they've quit.

She swaps them. Presses the lid of the bag flat with both
hands,

testing the pack of it.

LATER

The house dark. In the sewing room, one lamp. Peg at the Singer,

the kit bag's canvas lid under the needle. She sews something small

inside the underside of the flap - three sides, a pocket's worth of

stitches - snips the thread, and smooths the canvas down flat so

that nothing shows at all.

INT. ALVAREZ KITCHEN, EAST LOS ANGELES - NIGHT

A small kitchen, saints on the wall, a Singer older than NASA on

its own table by the window.

LITA, 80s, and Tito stand on opposite sides of the kitchen table.

Between them, spread the table's whole length: a flag. Hand-sewn.

The field of stars runs one star past even - fifty-one.

They fold it together. Lengthwise. Lengthwise again. Then Lita

starts the triangle folds from her end, tight and sharp, turning

the colors over and over into themselves while Tito keeps the

tension, and neither of them says one word.

The last fold tucks. A triangle of stars, packed tight.

Lita holds it a moment. Then she takes a small SAINT CHRISTOPHER

medal on a pin from her apron pocket and pins it deep inside the

last fold, where it will touch nothing but flag.

She puts the triangle in Tito's hands.

He kisses her forehead. Takes his cap off the chair, and goes.

Through the window, under the streetlight, he sets the triangle on

the truck seat with both hands.

Lita sits back down at the Singer and turns off the lamp.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, MAIN GATE - PRE-DAWN

4:00 AM by the guard shack clock. A farm truck rolls up to the

contractor lane. DANNY at the wheel, seed cap. In the bed and cab:

four men in gray coveralls - CRICKET, DUTCH, STITCH, GUNNY - with

lunch coolers and a laminated work order.

The GATE GUARD scans the order: VALLEY SALVAGE & SURPLUS - ARCHIVAL

UNIT FINAL SERVICING, BAY 1. Four names that aren't theirs.

GATE GUARD

Y'all know where you're going?

GUNNY

Son, we were servicing this bay before your daddy made the varsity.

The guard waves them through. Danny eases the truck in, knuckles

white on the wheel, eyes forward.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, CARGO INTEGRATION HALL - PRE-DAWN

The six crates in their cradles. Pell, early, stands at LOT F

peeling his own impound sticker while MACK holds out a document.

PELL
Attachment E-6. Notarized.
Backdated to March, I notice.

MACK
Filed in March. Copied slow.

PELL
Everything about you people is
slow.

He initials the release, unhappy about it, and walks the
row one

last time — a long look down the stenciled flanks — then
off toward

the observation mezzanine.

THE SERVICING

The four "contractors" work the crates with purge carts
and torque

wrenches — competent, unhurried, invisible. Joss's dock
crew moves

around them, seeing nothing.

One by one, unhurried, each old man steps up on a cart,
into a

crate, and lies back into the molded couch.

Cricket is last. He sets his kit bag between his knees,
looks up at

Joss standing over him with the lid hoist — and past him,
at the

hall's high steel, the cranes, the morning light coming up
the

windows.

CRICKET
Tuesday net's at nineteen hundred,
your frequency card's taped
under the console. Don't
improvise.

JOSS
Copy. No improvising.

CRICKET

And Joss. Thank your dad for the
radio.

Joss looks at him a second.

JOSS

Fly good, old man.

The lid comes down. Torque gun, eight bolts, a hiss as the
purge

line seats.

Joss raps the lid: knock-knock – pause – knock-knock.

From inside, muffled and exact: knock-knock – knock-knock.

He moves down the line. Raps LOT B. Answer. LOT C. Answer.
LOT D.

Answer. Four crates, four heartbeats.

At LOT E, Tito – contractor coveralls, cap backwards –
sets a

canvas-wrapped triangle into a padded corner mount, checks
it

twice with two knuckles, and seals the lid on the rest of
the gear:

tarped shapes, latched cases, gear.

THE RANDOM CHECK

A DOCKWORKER, 50s, Frontier badge, twenty-year lanyard
tape on the

clip, works the pre-stack checklist crate to crate. Torque
seals.

Purge pressure. Latch flags.

At LOT D, the checklist stops him: one latch flag showing
amber.

Procedure. He unslings his wrench, breaks the inspection
latch, and

lifts the service panel.

Inside, packed in the molded couch, kit bag between his
knees, eyes

open: CRICKET DAWES, looking straight up at him.

One second. Two. Three.

The Dockworker looks at the manifest on his clipboard. At the

inspection tag in the holder: INSPECTED - J. PELL. At the old man

in the crate, who does not blink.

The Dockworker resets the latch. Seats the panel. Signs the line.

INSERT: the checklist, block letters: LOT D - ALL CLEAR.

He moves to LOT E without looking back.

THE STACK

The transporter takes the crates out the high door into the dawn,

six in a row, stencils catching the light: OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE.

OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS. SUPPLEMENTARY CONTAINMENT. SUPPLEMENTARY

CONTAINMENT.

Mack and Joss watch from the dock edge. Mack signs the contractor

crew OUT - four names, one pen, no one watching.

JOSS

Net's quiet. Two clicks if it stays that way.

MACK

Go home. Sleep. Tired men look guilty.

Joss almost smiles. Doesn't manage it. The crates ride away toward

the stacking cell, small against the building, then smaller.

CUT TO:

EXT. FRONTIER LAUNCH COMPLEX, PAD 1 - NIGHT

The rocket stands in its own light, primer-white flank
blank where

the flag was. Vapor bleeds off the stages and rolls down
the hull.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - NIGHT

Blackness. Then a small amber bus light steadies, and
there is

Cricket's face by its glow, flat on his back in the molded
couch,

kit bag between his knees.

Through the structure: pumps starting somewhere far below,
a hum

climbing through the frame into his shoulder blades.

He puts one hand flat on the lid above his face.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM, WASHINGTON - NIGHT

Chandeliers and a thousand guests. UNITY EVE in living
flowers

across the stage. At center, a scale model of the Harmony
Banner

under glass.

Marwani works the room in black tie, handshake to
handshake. On a

screen the size of a barn door: the live pad feed.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

Rows of consoles. In a glassed VIP row, VESS, standing,
arms

folded. Beside her, PELL with a commemorative program.

At a podium off the floor, HALE reads to a camera, voice
level and

dead.

HALE
Frontier is honored to carry the
Lunar Heritage Neutralization
Accord to flight. Tonight belongs
to the community of nations.

He steps away from the podium before the light on the
camera is

off.

EXT. PAD 1, CREW ACCESS ARM - NIGHT

The HARMONY CREW crosses in white suits, helmets under
arms:

CMDR. BRANDT, silver at the temples; MAJ. LINDQVIST;
OBSERVER SHEN,

a head shorter, mission patch of the 44-nation banner.

At the hatch, Brandt pauses. Looks up the whole height of
the

stack, a long way, to where the vapor curls off into the
dark. Then

he goes in.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

Full house, quiet. Every face turned to the TV: the pad,
the clock.

Earlene has stopped pretending to wipe anything.

BUCK
There she goes in a minute. Ours.
Whatever's riding her.

Nobody answers him. The Cook comes out of the kitchen and
stands

with his towel over his shoulder.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM - NIGHT

Marwani takes the stage, flute in hand. The room hushes.
On the

barn-door screen behind him, the countdown clock walks down through

ninety seconds.

MARWANI

Tonight a rocket rises with no flag on its side. Think of that. Not conquest. Not pride. Repair. A machine built by the old America, flying the first errand of the new one.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - NIGHT

The hum has become a shudder. Dust ticks off the lid seam in the

amber light. Cricket's breathing stays even, eyes open.

MARWANI (V.O.)

(over the ballroom

PA, distant)

— so raise a glass, to a healed sky —

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

LAUNCH DIRECTOR (O.S.)

— three. Two. One.

EXT. PAD 1 - NIGHT

Ignition. The night goes orange for a mile. The rocket climbs off

the pad on a column of fire, slow, then not slow.

INT. KENNEDY BALLROOM - NIGHT

The screen floods the ballroom with launch light. A thousand flutes

tip together. Applause swells over the engine roar in the feed.

INT. CARGO BAY, CRATE D - LAUNCH

Weight. The couch takes Cricket deep into its molding, jaw pulled

back, hand still flat on the lid. The amber light dims under the

load — holds — comes back.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The rocket climbs on the TV. The diner watches it go, faces lit by

the screen. Wade the deputy, at the counter in civvies, has his hat

off, held against his chest.

EXT. SPACE - LATER

Engine cutoff. The roar stops all at once. The ship coasts, sunrise

crawling up the curve of the Earth below, the white hull going gold

along one edge.

INT. CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Dark and still. Cricket's kit bag floats up off his knees to the

end of its lanyard and hangs there, drifting.

A sound in the dark bay. Two knocks. Pause. Two knocks.

From another crate: two knocks — two knocks.

A third crate answers. Then a fourth.

The bay hangs quiet, four amber lights burning in four sealed

boxes, the Earth turning gold in the one small window across the

bay.

CUT TO:

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - SHIP'S NIGHT

The bay dark except for panel standby glow. Six crates ranked and

strapped, four amber lights showing at their vent slits. Beyond the

one small window, the Earth, whole, the size of a dinner plate and

shrinking.

A knock sequence taps out of crate B - long-short rhythms, patient.

INT. CRATE C - CONTINUOUS

Dutch, amber-lit, a pocket notebook against his knee. He pencils

letters as the knocks land, one at a time:

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK: "STITCH ASKS IF ANYONE ELSE'S HOTEL HAS ROOM

SERVICE."

Dutch reaches up without looking and knocks his reply on the crate

wall, slow and even.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK, next line: "TOLD HIM. TAKE IT UP WITH THE

SPEC AUTHOR."

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - LATER

The service rotation. Crate A's panel swings open from inside, slow,

and GUNNY floats out in thermal underwear and socks, a small kit

bag tethered to his wrist.

He works crate to crate in the dark, unhurried: swaps a scrubber

cartridge through Crate B's service port. Checks Crate C's
purge

gauge with a penlight hooded in his fist.

At Crate D, he unclips a steel thermos from his kit, opens
the vent

hatch, and passes it through.

CRICKET (O.S.)
(a whisper, from
inside)
Obliged.

Gunny closes the hatch to a half-inch. Turns for his own
crate —

The bay door seal hisses. Light spills in.

Gunny goes flat behind Crate F, one hand on a strap, socks
floating.

MAJ. LINDQVIST drifts in with a flashlight, coverall
sleeves rolled,

running a routine sweep. The beam walks down the stencils:
OLD

IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. The beam crosses the
half-open

vent hatch on Crate D.

Lindqvist frowns at it, pushes the hatch flush with one
finger

until it clicks, checks nothing else, and drifts back out.
The door

seals.

Dark again. Gunny lets go of the strap.

He crosses to the small window instead of his crate. Holds
the

frame with both hands.

Out there: the Moon, filling a third of the glass, gray
and coming.

Gunny looks at it a long time. Then he pushes off, floats
back into

Crate A, and pulls the panel shut behind him. The amber lights burn

in the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - SHIP'S DAY

Work lights on. OBSERVER SHEN floats the crate line alone, tablet

tethered to his wrist, stylus in hand. Cargo audit: serial by

serial, seal by seal.

He reads Crate A's stencil - OLD IDEAS - and enters the serial. The

purge gauge: nominal. He moves down the line.

OLD CULTURE. Serial. Gauge. Entry.

OLD CUSTOMS. Serial. Gauge. Entry.

At OLD HABITS - Crate D - he stops.

He holds still, head tilted a few degrees.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket, flat in the amber glow. A shadow lies across his vent

slit and does not move.

He stops breathing. Not slowly - all at once, mid-breath, held.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Shen drifts closer to the crate. Reads the inspection tag:

INSPECTED - J. PELL. Reads the serial. Checks the gauge - nominal,

steady.

Then he takes off one glove, wedges it under his arm, and lays his

bare palm flat on the crate's skin.

He leaves it there.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket, breath held, eyes on the lid an inch above his face. The

only sound in here is his own heart, loud, and getting louder.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

Shen's palm on the metal. His face gives nothing. Five seconds.

Eight.

Behind him, the bay door: CMDR. BRANDT drifts halfway in.

BRANDT

Shen. Burn prep. Straps in twenty.

Shen doesn't startle. He lifts his palm from the crate, works his

glove back on, and makes an entry on the tablet.

INSERT — THE TABLET: LOT D — SEALS INTACT. PURGE NOMINAL.
NO

ANOMALY.

He follows Brandt out. The lights bank down to standby.
The door

seals.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket lets the breath go, slow, through his teeth.

A moment. Then, from Crate C, very soft through the walls:
two

knocks.

Cricket reaches up and answers: two knocks.

The amber light burns. Nothing else moves.

CUT TO:

EXT. DAWES FARM, PORCH - DAY

A single black SUV in the drive - one, this time, and washed. A

young WHITE HOUSE AIDE in a good coat stands at the bottom of the

porch steps, holding a phone out flat on his upturned palm.

On the porch: PEG, arms crossed. DANNY beside her, sleeves rolled.

MARWANI (V.O.)

(from the phone,
warm)

Mrs. Dawes. I hope I find you
well. Is the Commander home?

PEG

He's out.

MARWANI (V.O.)

Of course. Mrs. Dawes, the country
is about to share a difficult,
beautiful day, and the President -
I - would rather share it whole
than divided. There are men, I'm
told, for whom the past fifty
years were a wound. Your husband
trained for something that was
taken from him. I cannot give him
back the years. But I can give
him the rest.

Peg says nothing. The aide's arm is getting tired.

MARWANI (V.O.)

The pension, made whole - that's
done, as a gesture. The record,
amended: Apollo Eighteen entered
into the rolls with his name on
the crew. Flown status, conferred
by executive order - the title,
the wings, the history. All of it,
Mrs. Dawes. On one condition.
Unity Day passes undisturbed - and
your husband watches it at
home. On his porch. Visibly. Where
the country can see a great

American at peace with a new
world.

Wind in the shelterbelt. Peg looks at the phone on the
young man's

palm.

PEG
I'll pass it along if he phones.

MARWANI (V.O.)
Mrs. Dawes—

PEG
You have a good day now.

She goes inside. The screen door claps. Danny stays a beat
longer,

looking at the aide, then follows her in. The aide is left
holding

his own phone out to a farmhouse.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD, NEBRASKA - NIGHT

Joss's truck on a high section road, tailgate down, a wire
antenna

run from a mast clamp to a fencepost. Joss works a morse
key by

red flashlight, a paper of cipher groups taped to the
tailgate.

Danny leans on the fender, watching the sky.

JOSS
Pass is six minutes. It's enough.

He keys. Stops. Listens to the hiss.

INT. CRATE D - NIGHT (LOW EARTH ORBIT)

The amber light. Morse, thin and far, ticking in Cricket's
earpiece.

He copies letters onto his pad, steady, no expression.

The pad fills: PENSION WHOLE. RECORD AMENDED. FLOWN
STATUS. EXEC

ORDER. CONDITION: HOME ON PORCH UNITY DAY. VISIBLE.

Cricket looks at the word VISIBLE a moment.

He rests his knuckle twice on the crate wall - pause - twice. From

crate C, twice - twice back. From B. From A.

Then he takes the key wired at his hip and sends, short and even.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss copies onto the tailgate paper, letter by letter, lips moving.

Then he stops keying back. Reads it. Reads it again.

DANNY

What's he say?

JOSS

(reading)

"Tell him: you can't give back
what you never had."

Danny looks at the paper. At the sky.

JOSS

There's more.

Joss's pencil finishes the last group.

JOSS

"Dawes out."

Overhead, among all the fixed stars, one moving point of light

crosses the dark, west to east, steady.

They watch it go all the way to the horizon.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - NIGHT

The floor quiet and full. On the main screen, the ship's track

curls away from the Earth line toward a drawn gray circle.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR
Flight controllers, go no-go for
trans-lunar injection. Guidance.

CONTROLLER (O.S.)
Go.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR
Propulsion.

CONTROLLER #2 (O.S.):
Go.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR
Harmony One, you are go for TLI.

In the glass VIP row, Vess stands alone at the rail.
Behind her,

Pell works through a commemorative program with a
highlighter.

BRANDT (V.O.)
(on the loop)
Copy. Go for TLI.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS

The bay in standby glow. Four amber lights at four vent
slits.

A clunk through the structure. Then the push - long,
smooth,

gathering - straps creaking taut against the crates.

INT. CRATE D - CONTINUOUS

Cricket pressed back into the couch, the amber light
steady, his

hand flat on the lid. The burn goes on. And on.

Then: cutoff. Weightless again. The kit bag floats up to
the end

of its lanyard.

INT. CRATE C - CONTINUOUS

Dutch, pencil out, runs figures in the notebook margin - velocity,

a time, an arc - and boxes the result, twice.

INSERT - THE NOTEBOOK: BURN NOMINAL. COAST 62 HRS. NO ABORT MODES

REMAIN.

He looks at the boxed line a moment. Then he knocks on his crate

wall: two - two.

Two - two, from D. Two - two, from B. Two - two, from A.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The track on the main screen bends out of Earth's neighborhood for

good. Applause on the floor, brief and professional.

Vess watches the line go. She lets go of the rail, one finger at a

time.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR

Trajectory nominal. Sixty-two hours to lunar orbit insertion, gentlemen. Get some sleep.

Pell caps his highlighter.

PELL

Well. Nothing stopping it now.

Vess doesn't answer him.

CUT TO:

END OF ACT TWO

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - DAY

Every console manned, every screen the same: the gray surface

coming up under the lander's camera, dust beginning to streak.

BRANDT (V.O.)
(on the loop)
Two hundred feet. Down at three.
Picking up some dust.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Standing room only. The TV huge in the corner. Nobody eats.

INT. JOSS'S TRUCK, RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss and Danny shoulder to shoulder in the cab, a phone propped on

the dash streaming the feed, the ham rig silent beside it.

BRANDT (V.O.)
(on the phone,
compressed)
Fifty feet. Forty. Contact light -
engine stop.

The dust settles on every screen in America. HARMONY ONE stands on

the Sea of Tranquility, primer-white, flagless.

The diner watches, still. Somebody's coffee goes cold untouched.

EXT. SEA OF TRANQUILITY - LUNAR DAY

Silence and glare. The lander's shadow long across the regolith.

The crew works the base-station deployment: BRANDT and LINDQVIST

wrestling a solar array true, SHEN anchoring a comms mast, all

three helmet-cams feeding Earth. A camera boom pans slow across

the site for the broadcast.

Behind the lander, in its blind spot, the cargo ramp is down.

Four crates stand open on the ramp, lids back, couches empty.

Four suited figures move in the lander's shadow — suits fifty

years old, patched and re-hosed, the NASA meatball bright on every

chest. On one wrist cuff, a small brass

museum tag turns on its wire.

They cross-load gear from crates E and F onto the BACKUP ROVER —

tarped bundles, latched cases, a long soft-sided sleeve strapped

diagonal. Practiced. Unhurried. Not one wasted move.

The last man aboard is the tallest. He settles into the rover's

rear rack seat, raps the fender twice — pause — twice.

The rover pulls away from the lander in a slow arc, out of the

shadow, into the sun, four men and their freight, tire tracks

unspooling behind it across ground no one has touched in fifty

years.

It gets small against the gray. Then it drops behind a rise and is

gone.

At the base station, Brandt straightens up from the array and

turns, helmet glare white.

BRANDT

(on the loop)

Base station nominal. Harmony One,
beginning retrieval operations
at first light tomorrow, per the
program.

Behind him, far off over the rise, a thin dust hangs a moment, and
settles.

CUT TO:

EXT. SURVEYOR CRATER, APOLLO 12 SITE - LUNAR DAY

The prime rover crests a low ridge, camera boom high,
three suits

aboard. Below: the Apollo 12 descent stage, gold foil
still bright,

experiment packages ranked where men left them in 1969.

LINDQVIST
(reading from a cue
card clipped to his
cuff)

"We arrive as guests of history,
to relieve it of its oldest
burden—"

He stops reading.

Where the flag should stand: a socket hole in the gray.
Around it,

bootprints — crisp, recent, not theirs. And leading in and
out of

the site, wheel tracks.

BRANDT
Harmony, Site One. The artifact
is... not present.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

Rows of faces, nobody moving. On the main screen, the
empty socket

hole, full screen.

FLIGHT DIRECTOR
Say again, Harmony One?

BRANDT (V.O.)
The flag is gone. The site is
otherwise intact. We observe

recent
surface activity. Bootprints.
Vehicle tracks.

INT. UNITY DAY PAVILION, WASHINGTON - CONTINUOUS

A daytime stage dressed in harmony blue, schoolchildren
holding

little Harmony Banners. Marwani mid-remarks at a podium,
teleprompter

rolling. Behind him, on the giant screen: the live feed
cuts to a

graphic — PLEASE STAND BY: UNITY DAY.

An AIDE climbs the stage steps and whispers. Marwani keeps
smiling

at the children while he listens.

INT. JOSS'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

The phone on the dash: a jittery re-stream of the raw
feed, chat

scrolling too fast to read.

JOSS

They can't cut the raw loop. It
relays through nine countries.

DANNY

Where are the flags, Joss?

Joss looks at the ham rig. Says nothing. Two clicks come
out of it,

soft. Then two more.

EXT. FRA MAURO, APOLLO 14 SITE - LATER

The rover parked. Three suits standing at another socket
hole,

another ring of prints, the same wheel tracks arriving and
leaving.

Lindqvist holds his cue card, doesn't read it.

ON A STREAMER'S FEED (INSET)

A man in a gaming chair, veins out.

STREAMER

There were NEVER any flags! Fifty
years of soundstage! They're on
the Moon looking for PROPS,
people! WAKE UP!

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The TV: the socket hole again. Buck turns his cup a
quarter turn.

BUCK

Somebody took 'em.

EARLENE

Took 'em where, Buck? It's the
Moon.

Buck drinks his coffee. On his face, slowly, the beginning
of a

smile.

EXT. FRA MAURO - CONTINUOUS

Brandt stands over the wheel tracks. Follows them with his
visor to

where they run off northwest, dead straight, out of sight.

He switches to the private crew loop. Click.

SHEN

(on the private
loop)

Commander. The possibility must be
raised. If the artifacts were
never — if the landings themselves
were—

BRANDT

Don't.

Silence on the loop. Shen looks at the bootprints — fifty
years of

undisturbed prints around the socket, and the new ones
laid over

them, crisp-edged, fresh.

BRANDT
Mount up. Last site on the
program.

LINDQVIST
Tranquility Base.

Brandt takes one more look northwest along the wheel
tracks. Dead

straight. Toward Tranquility.

BRANDT
Whoever they are, they're not
hiding their driving.

CUT TO:

EXT. APPROACH TO TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

The prime rover parked at the foot of a long, low rise.
The three

Harmony astronauts climb it on foot, single file, the
camera boom

and their helmet-cams feeding Earth.

BRANDT
(on the loop)
Harmony, on foot, one hundred
meters from Tranquility Base
perimeter. Site should be visual
past this rise.

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

Every screen: the bobbing helmet-cam view, gray ground,
black sky,

the rise coming up.

The chest-mounted camera clears the rise before any man's
helmet

does.

On the main screen, over the lip of ground: COLOR.

A CONTROLLER stands up so fast his headset cord snaps taut. Nobody

says anything. The image steadies as Brandt keeps climbing, seeing

nothing yet but his own boots.

FULL FRAME, TO EARTH:

Six American flags. Vibrant — red, white, blue against the black —

five of them planted in a wide ring around the low hill of Tranquility Base, and at the center, on the original pole, raised

again where it fell in 1969: the first one.

Inside the ring: four webbed aluminum lawn chairs. A squat steel

grill on legs, hoses run to a bottle, a curl of vapor flashing off

its seams. A card table. On the card table, a cooler.

And four old men in fifty-year-old suits, three seated, one

standing at the grill with a long spatula, all facing the rise.

Behind the party, stood on end in a row, side by side: four

emptied crates, stenciled faces out —

OLD IDEAS. OLD CULTURE. OLD CUSTOMS. OLD HABITS.

Planted beside the grill, smaller than the six, on a workshop

flagpole: a hand-sewn flag with one star too many.

A tripod stands off to the side — their own camera, a red light on

it, its feed already on Earth's internet.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The TV. The ring of flags. The lawn chairs.

Buck is on his feet. So is everybody.

BUCK
There they are.

INT. UNITY DAY PAVILION - CONTINUOUS

Marwani, mid-sentence, feels the crowd's eyes go past him.
He

turns. The screen behind him holds the ring of flags,
forty feet

tall.

The schoolchildren, front row, see flags and lawn chairs
and a

cookout.

They cheer.

INT. FRONTIER TRAINING ROOM (WATCH PARTY) - CONTINUOUS

Folding chairs, sheet cake. The FACILITATOR from Module 7
stands

frozen with a paper plate, reading her own slide off the
crate

lids.

ON A STREAMER'S FEED (INSET)

The streamer, mid-rant, stops. His jaw works. Dead air,
chat

avalanching.

EXT. TRAM STOP, WARSAW - NIGHT

Strangers packed around one phone. The ring of flags glows
off

their faces. Somebody starts to clap. Others join. It
spreads down

the platform.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt's eyes finally clear the rise. He stops walking.
Lindqvist

stops behind him. Shen stops last.

The three of them stand on the lip of the ground, looking
down at

the most illegal Fourth of July in human history.

At the grill, the tall suited figure sees them,
straightens up,

and raises the spatula — unhurried, all the way up.

Hold on that.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

Brandt comes down the rise slow, hands visible, Lindqvist
and Shen

behind him. The ring of flags stands around them, colors
hard in

the sun. The tripod camera's red light burns.

Brandt stops ten meters out. Keys his radio.

BRANDT

Switching to channel two. Let's
talk privately, gentlemen.

The old man at the grill doesn't move. The one in the
second chair

— CRICKET, gray stubble behind the visor glass — keys the
OPEN

loop.

CRICKET

We'll talk right here, where
everybody can hear us. We've got
nothing to hide. You?

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The Flight Director looks at the loop status: OPEN. Every word

going to Earth raw. Nobody moves to change it.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt looks back at his crew. Then walks closer. Reads the crate

lids, left to right. Reads the small flag with too many stars.

Reads the grill.

LINDQVIST

(blurting)

Where did you even COME from?

CRICKET

We came in the mail.

A beat.

BRANDT

(formal, for the record)

This site is designated for retrieval under the Lunar Heritage Neutralization Accord. I am required to ask who you are and by what authority you interfere.

The old men look at each other. Cricket stands up out of his lawn

chair, unhurried, and faces him.

CRICKET

We're the backup crew. NASA never processed us out. We're still on the roster, son. This is our mission.

STITCH

(from his chair, not getting up)

And friendly as I know how to say it: this here's our camp. Pack the fuck off.

INT. WHITE HOUSE, COUNSEL'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Four LAWYERS around a speakerphone, laptops open. One of them has

a personnel file on screen: DAWES, E. — ASTRONAUT (ACTIVE). A

fifty-year column of quarterly entries: \$0.00. \$0.00. \$0.00.

LAWYER #1:

Tell me this is a database error.

LAWYER #2:

It's been signed off every quarter since 1972, by career staff,

under four statutes. And three months ago somebody reactivated the

annuity — we did — which means this administration AFFIRMED the

status—

LAWYER #1:

So they're not trespassers.

LAWYER #2:

They're federal personnel on their duty station. If that crew

removes them on camera, the crew of a foreign-flagged mission will

be laying hands on serving American officers. On live television.

On the Fourth of July.

Silence around the speakerphone.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Shen steps forward, past Brandt, toward the nearest flag in the

ring.

All four old men come out of their chairs at once — no signal

given, none needed — and stand between him and the colors.

Shen stops.

The one from the grill — GUNNY, tallest, spatula still in hand —

looks down at him through the visor glass a long moment.
Then

points the spatula, once, back at the Harmony rover.

Nobody on the open loop says anything. Nobody moves.

BRANDT
(on the loop, eyes
on the old men)
Harmony copies. Control — Harmony
requests instructions.

The old men sit back down, one at a time, Cricket last.
Gunny goes

back to the grill and flips what's on it.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

The Flight Director stands at his console, headset half-off,

looking at a message on his screen: WASHINGTON DIRECTS:
PROCEED

WITH RETRIEVAL PER ACCORD SCHEDULE. ACKNOWLEDGE.

He looks at it a long moment. Then he takes the headset
all the

way off and sets it on the console.

A new voice comes onto the loop anyway — accented, smooth,
piped

in from somewhere that is not this room.

ACCORD COORDINATOR (V.O.)
Harmony One, this is Accord
Coordination, Geneva. You are

directed
to proceed with retrieval of all
six artifacts. Immediately,
please.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt stands in the ring of flags. He looks at the old
men in

their lawn chairs. At the first flag, center, on its 1969
pole.

BRANDT
(quietly, on the
loop)
Copy, Geneva.

He walks to the nearest flag in the ring. Plants his
boots. And

reaches for the staff.

Four old men come out of four lawn chairs and step between
him and

the colors in one motion — a line, shoulder to shoulder,
visors

level, Cricket at the center.

Brandt's glove stops a foot short. He is looking at a
color guard.

Gunny, at the end of the line, keys the open loop. His
voice comes

slow and even, to Brandt, and to every living room on
Earth.

GUNNY
You want 'em? Come through us.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Everybody is already standing. Buck's fist comes down on
the

counter, once —

BUCK
U-S-A!

— and the diner takes it up, coffee cups rattling.

DINER
USA! USA! USA!

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

The carousel crew around a paint-spattered radio, brushes down,

two hundred voices pounding it out, gold leaf shaking off a

horse's bridle.

EXT. HIGHWAY OVERPASS - CONTINUOUS

Pickup trucks parked fender to fender. Men drop a flag the size of

a bedsheet over the rail into the wind above six lanes. Horns

below, hundreds, leaning on it.

INT. BROOKLYN LOFT, WATCH PARTY - CONTINUOUS

The UNITY DAY shirts crowd, forty of them, on their feet — half of

them chanting USA, USA, caught up in it, before some remember

themselves and stop, hands over mouths.

Some don't stop.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - CONTINUOUS

Joss, truck door open, working the morse key fast. Danny beside

him, hands on top of his head.

INT./EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

In Cricket's earpiece, thin and far, morse — three letters, over

and over.

Behind the glass, Cricket swallows once.

Brandt lowers his arm. Steps back — one step.

SHEN
(private loop)
Commander. Your orders—

BRANDT
(private loop)
I know my orders.

He keys back to open.

BRANDT
Geneva, Harmony One. The site
is... occupied by personnel
asserting
jurisdiction. Requesting political
guidance.

Long static. On the card table, unhurried, Gunny deals
four hands

of cards.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

The TV: PRESIDENT MARWANI at the briefing-room podium,
flags of

forty-four nations pinned behind him.

MARWANI
(on TV)
This morning I directed Frontier
Aerospace to restore mission
control and end this provocation.
Not because we fear four old
men. Because the world deserves
the day it was promised. The
company's obligations are clear.
So are the consequences of
failing them.

He steps away from the podium without questions.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, PRESS ROOM - DAY

Live lights. Cameras banked three deep. HALE at the podium, a

single prepared page in his hand. Off-stage, in the dark of the

wings: VESS, arms folded, watching.

Hale flattens the page on the podium. Reads, in the dead voice.

HALE

"Frontier Aerospace condemns the unauthorized occupation of the Tranquility site, and will comply fully with federal direction to..."

He stops. Looks at the next line. The room waits, shutters clicking.

He folds the page in half. And in half again. And sets it down,

squared to the podium's edge.

HALE

I can't read this one.

He looks straight into the bank of cameras. When he speaks again,

the flatness is gone.

HALE

Two years, you threatened everything I built, and I complied. I painted the flag off my own rocket. I read your statements in your words like a man in somebody's basement. I watched the mother of my children get called a traitor for running my company better than I ever did. That's over, as of the following sentence.

He takes one breath.

HALE

You want to nationalize me? Go. Fuck. Yourself.

Flashes. Bedlam. Aides somewhere off-camera shouting the feed

down, and failing, because the feed is his.

Hale steps off the podium. Passes Vess in the wings. Stops. The

two of them look at each other, one beat, two.

He keeps walking. She watches him go. The corner of her mouth

moves.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

Frozen. Then BUCK laughs — one short bark — and slaps the counter.

The COOK looks at the carbon meter on his gas line. Then he turns

the flat-top burners up, all the way, all of them.

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, LOBBY - DUSK

Doors bang open. PELL crosses the marble at speed with two FEDERAL

MARSHALS, tablet under his arm, lanyard swinging.

PELL
(to the desk, not
stopping)
Where is the override room, and
where is Mira Vess?

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, VESS'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Corner office, lights low, the launch complex out the glass. VESS

stands behind her desk. On the desk: one folder, squared to the

blotter.

The door opens. PELL, marshals behind him.

VESS

They wait in the hall.

PELL

They're federal marshals.

VESS

Then they'll be comfortable
standing.

Pell looks at her. Then nods the marshals back. The door
clicks.

PELL

Ms. Vess. I am here for the
mission override, and I am past
asking nicely.

VESS

There is no override. The ship
answers its crew. You built the
compliance regime, Administrator -
nothing at this company moves
without a signature. You know that
better than anyone.

She opens the folder. Takes out the first page. Lays it in
front

of him, turned to face him.

VESS

The integration re-weigh. Four
anomalous mass readings,
invalidated by calibration drift,
accepted into the federal record.
Countersigned.

His own signature, at the bottom.

VESS

Attachment E-6, releasing
containment unit F from impound.
Initialed.

The second page goes down. His initials.

VESS

Inspection certification,
containment unit D. Personally
executed.

The carbon of the orange tag: INSPECTED - J. PELL. She
lays a

fourth page beside it – the re-weigh acceptance, unit D
line

highlighted.

VESS

Twice.

Pell looks down at the pages. At his own name, four times,
in his

own hand.

PELL

You scheduled my inspections.

She takes out the last page and lays it down: a printed
calendar

memo. RANDOM COMPLIANCE RE-WEIGH – WINDOW PROPOSED PER M.
VESS

OFFICE.

PELL

(quiet)

Random means random.

VESS

It does.

Pell stares at the pages. His hand moves toward them,
stops.

PELL

The scale tech. Yours?

Vess looks at him and says nothing at all.

PELL

You understand what you've – if I
take this public, you go to
prison.

VESS

With every document bearing your
signature, Administrator.

She comes around the desk, past him, to the door, and
stops with

her hand on it.

VESS

You wanted the company to
cooperate. The company cooperated.
The
country didn't.

She opens the door and walks out through the marshals,
unhurried,

down the hall, gone.

Pell stands alone in her office, in front of the desk, the
pages

lined up facing the empty chair.

After a moment, he sits down in front of them, in the
visitor's

chair, and doesn't touch anything.

CUT TO:

INT. FRONTIER AEROSPACE, HALE'S OFFICE - NIGHT

Dark. The launch complex lit below the glass. Hale at the
desk,

tie gone, the phone in his hand.

He types two words. Looks at them.

INSERT - THE PHONE: Look up.

He posts it, and sets the phone face down on the desk.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The phone behind the register buzzes. Earlene reads it.
Shows the

Cook.

EXT. DAWES FARMHOUSE - NIGHT

The yard dark. The porch light comes on.

Off. On. Off - on, on.

PEG on the porch in her house coat, hand on the switch,
working it:

two - pause - two. Two - pause - two.

EXT. RIDGE ROAD - NIGHT

Joss's truck headlights answer across the dark section
land: two -

two. Danny, standing in the bed, watches farmhouse after
farmhouse

come alight down the valley - porch lights snapping on,
some

steady, some flashing, spreading fence line to fence line.

EXT. PIONEER FIELD, BALLPARK - NIGHT

Empty stands. The GROUNDSKEEPER at the breaker panel
throws the

light towers on - off - on, whole banks at a time, the
field

strobing under them.

EXT. AMERICA - NIGHT (AERIAL)

Suburb grids pulse. A skyline flickers block by block.
Highways

run bright with flashers. The dark country between cities
fills

with pinpoints, porch by porch, until there is no dark
country.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The card game. Stitch, holding his hand of cards, has
looked up -

past the flags, at the Earth hanging in the black.

STITCH

Y'all.

They look up. The four olds. Then Brandt. Then Lindqvist.
Then

Shen.

The night side of the Earth is flickering. Waves of light
crawl

across it — coastlines pulsing, whole seaboards going
bright and

dark and bright.

Seven visors tilt back, the Earth small and bright in
every one of

them.

Nobody says anything for a long time. The cards hang in
Stitch's

glove, forgotten.

At the grill, without looking away from the Earth, Gunny
reaches

over and turns down the burner.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The Earth still ripples with light. Gunny works the grill
— opens

the sealed press, and there they are, in rows, vapor
flashing off

them: burgers.

Brandt watches from three meters, and his voice arrives on
the

open loop, unguarded.

BRANDT
...is that a burger?

INT. FRONTIER MISSION CONTROL - CONTINUOUS

A beat of dead air on the floor. Then a controller snorts.
Then

the whole back row goes.

ON SCREENS AROUND THE WORLD

The clip replays instantly, captioned in forty languages.
IS THAT

A BURGER? crawls under the ring of flags on every network.

EXT. TRAM STOP, WARSAW - NIGHT

The platform crowd, bigger now, howls.

INT. GENEVA, ACCORD PRESS ROOM - DAY

The ACCORD COORDINATOR at a lectern, gray suit, grim.

ACCORD COORDINATOR
The retrieval program remains, in
the Accord's view, scheduled -

The press row laughs. Not politely. He looks down at his
notes,

and a minister seated behind him checks his phone and
grins before

he can stop himself.

INT. WHITE HOUSE, PRESS BRIEFING ROOM - DAY

The PRESS SECRETARY at the podium, gripping it.

PRESS SECRETARY
The President believes the
situation at the site has -
evolved -

A laugh from the back row. Then the middle rows. She
stands in it,

looking down at her briefing book.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Brandt looks at the burgers a long moment. Then he keys
the open

loop, formal, every word chosen.

BRANDT
Geneva, Harmony One. Site survey
complete. There is nothing at

Tranquility to retrieve. There is
a color guard, on station, under
national colors. Harmony One
stands down.

Static from Geneva. Nothing else.

Gunny loads a burger onto the long spatula and extends it
across

the three meters, steady.

Brandt looks at his crew. Lindqvist's glove comes up: go
on.

Brandt takes the burger and holds it up beside his visor --
the

enemy commander, the ring of flags, the flickering Earth
behind

him.

The tripod camera's red light burns. On every screen on
Earth, the

same frame.

Lindqvist accepts one too, laughing inside his helmet,
silent

behind glass.

Shen stands apart, arms folded. Gunny plates a burger
anyway and

sets it on the card table, in front of the empty fourth
chair,

facing him.

It sits there. Shen looks at it, and away.

INT. ROY'S DINER - NIGHT

The frame on the TV: Brandt and the burger. The Cook's
flat-top is

full edge to edge. He starts plating burgers nobody
ordered,

passing them down the counter, waving off every wallet
that comes

out.

Buck raises his coffee cup to the TV and holds it up a moment.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LATER

The card table cleared. Off to the side, angled toward the black

sky: a short rack of three mortar tubes, welded neat, cabled to a

firing box on the card table.

The four olds stand in a loose line inside the ring of flags.

Brandt and Lindqvist stand behind them. Shen stands apart, arms

folded, but he stands.

Gunny takes a folded photocopy from his wrist pocket and opens it

with both gloves. When he speaks, it is slower, and older.

GUNNY

John Adams. Wrote this to his wife, July of 1776, about this day.

He reads.

GUNNY

"It ought to be solemnized with pomp and parade. With shows, games, sports, guns, bells, bonfires and illuminations - from one end of this continent to the other. From this time forward. Forevermore."

He folds the paper and puts it away.

GUNNY

Two hundred and fifty years, and here we all are. One end of the

continent to the other — and a
little past it.

INT. TRI-COUNTY AUCTION BARN - CONTINUOUS

The carousel floor. Two hundred men, Joss, Danny, and TITO
around

the radio and a live feed. On the loop, Cricket's voice.

CRICKET (V.O.)
Tito Alvarez. You built the tubes.
Count us down.

Tito looks around the barn. Two hundred faces looking
back. Danny

puts a hand on his shoulder.

Tito leans to the microphone.

TITO
(into the mic)
Tres... dos... uno.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Gunny's glove closes the circuit.

The first shell rides a hard straight spark into the black
— no

arc, no drift, dead true — and breaks.

RED. A perfect sphere, edges clean, expanding and
expanding and

not stopping, no air to slow it, and no sound at all.

INT. ROY'S DINER - CONTINUOUS

The whole room lit red off the TV. Nobody blinks.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The second shell breaks WHITE — a sphere inside the fading
red

one, rings within rings, drifting up through itself in the
vacuum.

EXT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, PORCH - NIGHT

Peg on the porch, the TV's glow through the window laying white

light across her face. Her hand is on the porch light switch. She

leaves it on, steady now.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

The white sphere hangs over the six flags and the small fifty-one-star one. Cricket steps forward, next to the first flag,

the one raised back up where it fell.

He keys the open loop - to the crew, to the diner, to Warsaw, to

the barn, to Geneva, to every person on the lit face of the Earth.

CRICKET

It's Independence Day.

A beat. The whole channel, the whole planet, quiet.

CRICKET

God bless America.

Gunny closes the circuit on the third tube.

The shell rides its spark up past the flags, up past the white

sphere's last embers, and breaks BLUE-WHITE, dead center over the

ring, a sphere that swells until it takes the entire frame

—

WHITE OUT.

Hold in the white. Silence.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - LUNAR DAY

Days later. The party looks lived-in now: cable runs, a supply

line of cases walked over from the Harmony lander, the flags

holding their ring.

At the lander, load-up. Stitch and Dutch carry the last cases up

the ramp. Gunny walks crate F's remaining stores the other way -

toward the base station - stacking them neat without being asked.

Brandt watches Cricket, who has not started for the ramp.

BRANDT

We have four couches rigged.

CRICKET

Three's enough.

Brandt looks at him. At the ring of flags. Back at him. Then he

nods once, and goes to supervise the loading.

Dutch comes down the ramp with his binder. He opens the rings,

pulls a section - pages of margins, tables, his own handwriting -

and hands them over.

DUTCH

Consumable margins, four pages.
The scrubber schedule is
non-negotiable. It's initialed.

CRICKET

It would be.

Gunny sets the last stores case down, squares it to the stack, and

faces Cricket. He doesn't say anything. He comes to attention and

holds out his hand, and they shake, one pump, done.

Stitch is last, at the foot of the ramp.

STITCH
Same time Tuesday.

CRICKET
Same time Tuesday.

Stitch climbs the ramp without looking back.

INT. HARMONY ONE, CABIN - LATER

Cramped. Three old men webbed into rigged restraints among three

astronauts in couches, knees and elbows everywhere. Foil-wrapped

burgers pass hand to hand, cold.

Lindqvist takes two, holds one out to Shen wedged beside him.

Shen looks at it. Takes it. Unwraps it, and eats.

Nobody says anything about it. Dutch, chewing, produces his pencil

and starts a fuel-margin calculation on the foil.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE - CONTINUOUS

Cricket stands clear of the blast radius, alone by the ring.

The ascent engine lights, silent. The lander rises on its spark,

up and over, dust settling in slow sheets — and he holds a salute

until it's one bright point among the stars.

Then he turns, and walks back to the flags, bootprints joining the

hundreds already there.

CUT TO:

INT. ROY'S DINER - DAY

Months on. The TV, sound low: C-SPAN. The vote board fills green.

CHYRON: RESTORATION OF FLIGHT STATUS ACT PASSES 98-2.
BACKUP CREWS

OF THE APOLLO PROGRAM ENTERED INTO THE ROLLS.

BUCK
Who were the two?

EARLENE
Does it matter?

BUCK
I'd like to know their addresses
is all.

The Cook sets a plate in front of a stranger. The carbon meter is

gone off the gas line — four screw holes where it sat.

INT. DAWES FARMHOUSE, KITCHEN - DAY

Peg at the table with the mail. She opens a government envelope —

linen again, eagle again.

INSERT — A PAY STUB: DAWES, E. — RANGER (FIRST),
TRANQUILITY BASE

NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK. And a number, a real one, with digits.

Peg reads it twice. Puts it under a magnet on the fridge, square,

where the family can see it.

The hutch drawer with the old check in it stays shut.

INT. DAWES BARN - NIGHT (TUESDAY)

The simulator hums on standby. DANNY sits at the ham rig with a

mug, headset on, logbook open — a fresh spiral notebook, his own

handwriting on the spine.

DANNY
(into the mic)
Net's open. Tuesday, nineteen-oh-
two local.

DUTCH (FILTERED)
Copy.

STITCH (FILTERED)
Here.

GUNNY (FILTERED)
On time for once, son.

A pause. Static, long-traveled, three seconds of light-lag
round

trip.

CRICKET (FILTERED)
(far, thin, clear)
Tranquility. Reading you all five
by five.

Danny grins at the rig and writes the time in the log.

EXT. TRANQUILITY BASE NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK - LUNAR NIGHT

A small hab module sits off the original site, resupply
pods

beside it. A carved sign faces the footprint trail:

TRANQUILITY BASE NATIONAL HISTORIC PARK — EST. JULY 4 —
RANGER

STATION NO. 1.

The six flags stand their ring, colors lit by Earthlight.
Over the

hab, on its workshop pole, the fifty-one-star flag.

CRICKET — suit patched at the knee, an arrowhead park
patch on his

chest — walks the ring's perimeter, checking each staff
with one

glove, a firm pull at each.

He finishes at the first flag, the one from 1969, and
looks up.

The Earth hangs full above the flags, night side facing –
dark

continents rimmed in city light.

Cricket raises one glove, all the way, and waves.

A beat.

On the dark face of the Earth: a city flickers. Then
another. Then

whole coastlines, pulsing – two, pause, two – the wave
rolling

westward across the night side, city by city, sea to sea.

Cricket holds his glove up, and the Earth keeps answering,
and the

flags hold their colors in the black.

FADE OUT.

THE END